safer, faster, and all-around more efficient way to do this, I introduced them to Tor.

The Tor Project was a creation of the state that ended up becoming one of the few effective shields against the state's surveillance. Tor is free and open-source software that, if used carefully, allows its users to browse online with the closest thing to perfect anonymity that can be practically achieved at scale. Its protocols were developed by the US Naval Research Laboratory throughout the mid-1990s, and in 2003 it was released to the public—to the worldwide civilian population on whom its functionality depends. This is because Tor operates on a cooperative community model, relying on tech-savvy volunteers all over the globe who run their own Tor servers out of their basements, attics, and garages. By routing its users' Internet traffic through these servers, Tor does the same job of protecting the origin of that traffic as the CIA's "non-attributable research" system, with the primary difference being that Tor does it better, or at least more efficiently. I was already convinced of this, but convincing the gruff COs was another matter altogether.

With the Tor protocol, your traffic is distributed and bounced around through randomly generated pathways from Tor server to Tor server, with the purpose being to replace your identity as the source of a communication with that of the last Tor server in the constantly shifting chain. Virtually none of the Tor servers, which are called "layers," know the identity of, or any identifying information about, the origin of the traffic. And in a true stroke of genius, the one Tor server that *does* know the origin—the very first server in the chain—*does not* know where that traffic is headed. Put more simply: the first Tor server that connects you to the Tor network, called a gateway, knows you're the one sending a request, but because it isn't allowed to read that request, it has no idea whether you're looking for pet memes or information about a protest, and the final Tor server that your request passes through, called an exit, knows exactly what's being asked for, but has no idea who's asking for it.

This layering method is called onion routing, which gives Tor its name: it's The Onion Router. The classified joke was that trying to surveil the Tor network makes spies want to cry. Therein lies the project's irony: here was a US military–developed technology that made cyberintelligence simultaneously harder and easier, applying hacker know-how to protect the anonymity of IC officers, but only at the price of granting that same anonymity to adversaries and to average users across the globe. In this sense, Tor was even more neutral than Switzerland. For me personally, Tor was a life changer, bringing me back to the